

| By Shafi Rahman |

Thanks to a printing error, the Right to Education Bill was mentioned as the "Fight" to Education Bill in one of the Parliament bulletins. With its complicated contest of grand visions and disappointing shortfalls, ambitions and embarrassments, the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Bill, to give it its full name, which hopes to cover the 10 crore children between the ages of six and 14 who are out of school, is indeed threatening to live up to the printer's devil.

Promising free and compulsory elementary education in a neighbourhood school and ensuring easy access to education unhindered by capitation fee, the bill, which was passed in the first session of the 15th Lok Sabha, says Kendriya Vidyalayas, Navodaya Vidyalayas, Sainik schools, and unaided schools should admit at least 25 per cent of their students from disadvantaged and economically weaker groups. Former vice-chairman of the National Knowledge Commission, biologist Pushpa M. Bhargava, has shot off a letter to the prime minister urging him not to pursue the effort, saying that the Government is subsidising private schools of low quality instead of strengthening its own schools. But the ministry, in a hurry to come up with a showy legislation in its 100-day dash, has not bothered to think through the problems like the need to create 20,000 new elementary schools.

There are more problems. One, the idea of neighbourhood schools, a great equaliser in theory and a working concept in several western nations, lays the onus of locating the school on the child, instead of making it mandatory for schools to educate all



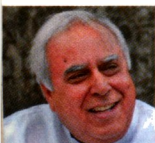
Still not **RIGHT**

The HRD Ministry, in its desperation to pass the Right to Education Bill, has neither allocated the required money nor resolved the ambiguities in its drafting

children. In effect, it will be legitimising the current discriminatory system where poor children will have access only to substandard schools while those of the middle-class or the elite will have access to Central or private schools. Needy students will have to approach neighbourhood school committees set up by the respective state governments to avail of free education. The more expensive schools where the disadvantaged students are directed to seek admission will be compensated with Government-grade fees. The students

will have to make good the shortfall. Add to this the other expenses.

Second, the bill doesn't specify what a neighbourhood school is, leaving it amorphous enough for the Government to define it any which way. Third, there seems to be confusion on how much it will cost the Government. In February 2008, the HRD Ministry had sent a financial estimate to the Cabinet Secretariat of Rs 2.28 lakh crore as additional expenses over the next seven years. The Saikia Committee, set up in 1997, has estimated a financial requirement of Rs 40,000 crore to bring 6.3 crore out-of-school children into school over a period of three years. The expert group constituted in 1998 by the government on the recommendations



“When you dream, you don't build a garden for everyone to walk. You look at the sky so that people can aspire.”

KAPIL SIBAL, Union HRD Minister